INT. APARTMENT - LIVING-ROOM - NIGHT

JAKE (26) walks through the door.

KIM (23) sits on the couch legs crossed

She reads with a sharp focus.

Jake sighs and leans his head against the door as he closes it with his hip.

He unties his tie looking up at the ceiling like it holds the answers to his struggles.

Kim seems unaffected by her husbands struggles, she flips the page.

KIM
Your dinner is in the microwave.
You are 12 minutes late so it might be a little cold.

Jake's eyes dart back at her slightly startled.

JAKE
Thanks..
Um..
Can I have a hug?

Kim’s eyes meet his like he said a sick joke.

KIM
Not happening.

Kim flips the page and keeps reading.

Jake peels himself off the door and walks to the kitchen.

JAKE
(under his breath)
Why did I ask?

INT. APARTMENT - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

He turns on the microwave again and leans back against the counter.

Jake looks down at his busy schedule.

He has meeting all day every day it seems.

JAKE
Honey?

Kim makes a noise of recognition from the living-room.

JAKE (cont'd)
(unenthusiastically)
When is Sam's party again?

KIM (O.S.)
Friday, 7 pm.

Jake runs his hand over his face.

JAKE
(frustrated)
Thank you!

Jake grabs his food and joins Kim on the couch.

INT. APARTMENT - LIVING-ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Kim shifts positions to be facing him more but on her side of the couch. Keeping a distance.

Jake turns on the TV and watches as he takes a bite.

JAKE
Why do meetings have to be so fucking boring?

Jake looking at the TV, holds up his finger, palm facing Kim.

JAKE (cont'd)
Don't answer that one.

Kim pauses her book, she glances up at the finger.

She turns her attention to the book.

KIM
(flat)
They are a necessary evil for a profession in corporate structures.

Jake rolls his eyes.

JAKE
I just said-

Kim turns a page deliberately, her expression unchanged.

KIM
And I responded with an objective statement.
(MORE)

KIM (cont'd)
Your request for silence was not specific enough.

Jake finishes his food and puts the plate on the coffee table.

He stands up.

JAKE
I'm gonna shower.

Kim nods once, still reading.

KIM
Water temperature is optimal at 102 degrees Fahrenheit.

Jake walks to the bathroom.

JAKE
(tired)
Thank you honey.

Kim nods again smaller this time.

JAKE (cont'd)
Towel warmed?

Kim takes her eyes off the book to check her watch.

KIM
It has been warming for 24 minutes. Should be sufficiently heated now.

Jake smirks at the question he is forming.

JAKE
How do you know?

Kim marks her place in the book.

She closes the book with a snap.

KIM
Simple. I calculated the time between your arrival and your typical eating duration. Simple math.

Jake thinks about the answer. Trying it himself for a second.

JAKE
Huh?

KIM
You were 12 minutes late, put 3 minutes on the microwave, you ate for 9 minutes.

Jake nods and closes the bathroom door.

JAKE (O.S.)
Okay..
Love you!

FADE TO:

INT. APARTMENT - BATHROOM - LATER

The water kicks off.

Jake opens the shower curtain.

There is a t-shirt, cotton shorts and boxer briefs folded up on the toilet lid.

Jake smiles at this.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

Kim seems to not have moved.

The Bathroom door opens behind her.

Kim doesn’t look up from her book.

KIM
Your hair is still damp. Dry it properly to prevent future irritation.

Jake pokes his head out to the sound of her voice.

JAKE
What kind of irritation?

Kim closes her book with a snap.

KIM
Cold water droplets can cause Minot skin irritation and potential respiratory issues if left untreated.

Jake pulls his head back into the bathroom.

JAKE (O.S.)
Respiratory issues?

Kim stands and walks to the bathroom doorway.

INT. APARTMENT - BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

KIM
Yes. The water evaporation could trigger a coughing response. Especially if you sleep with wet hair.

Jake smirks.

JAKE
What studies back this?

Kim leans against the doorframe.

KIM
Multiple studies show a correlation between wet hair and respiratory problems during sleep. It creates an ideal environment for bacteria growth.

Jake grabs his towel from the floor and dresses his hair.

Kim watches his action.

KIM (cont'd)
Good Choice. Your health matters.

Kim walks back to the couch and sits back down to read.

Jake look at himself in the mirror.

JAKE
So...
honey?

Kim makes a noise of attention.

JAKE (cont'd)
Do we have time scheduled for intimacy?

Kim adjusts her glasses while reading.

Her expression unchanged.

KIM
We have a scheduled intimate moment at 9:30PM tonight. It’s part of my weekly schedule as well.

Jake pokes his head out from the doorframe.

JAKE
Is that solid *OR* can it be adjusted?

Kim checks her watch.

KIM
It’s flexible within a 15 minute window. Why do you ask?

Jake shrugs.

JAKE
Just wondering.

Kim raises an eyebrow slightly.

KIM
Your curiosity suggests something specific is on your mind.

Jake turns off the bathroom light and walks to join her.

JAKE
I am just trying to see how solid our schedule is today.

Kim sets her book down at seeing him approach.

KIM
My schedule is designed for efficiency and adaptability. If there’s an adjustment needed, I can accommodate it within reason.

Jake sits next to her.

JAKE
And I have full confidence that you can.

Kim watches him sit analytical.

KIM
Your confidence is noted. What channel would you prefer tonight?

JAKE
Hand me the control.

KIM
Very well. The remote is yours to command.

JAKE
How many?

KIM
Currently 23 channels. You're on channel 12 now.

JAKE
What channel is Alt.News24:48 on?

KIM
Channel 47.

JAKE
Thank you.

KIM
You're welcome. I exist to provide information when needed.

JAKE
Babe. You are human.

KIM
Yes. I posses human anatomy and physiology.

JAKE
You are a woman.

KIM
Indeed, I am a female. Does that surprise you?

JAKE
No, I just don't want you thinking you are robot. You can get fatigued, you can get sick.

KIM
I understand the difference. I do not require maintenance like a robot, but I can experience physical discomfort. I appreciate your reminder.

JAKE
No you don't.

KIM
I do. I appreciate the intention behind your reminder. Even If I may not show it outwardly.

JAKE
I understand.

Kim nods as she watches TV.

JAKE (cont'd)
So, What do we have planned for tomorrow?

KIM
You have a meeting with your professor at 12pm. Followed by grocery shopping at 2pm.

JAKE
Does our day start at 10?

KIM
Yes. We should be ready by 9:30 for breakfast, then leave promptly at 9:45.

JAKE
Understood.

KIM
Currently it is 8:17pm. You should start preparing for bed soon.

JAKE
I think, I will stay up a little longer.

KIM
As you wish. But do not stay up past midnight. Your sleep schedule must remain consistent.

Jake pulls her into his side.

Kim stiffens at the unexpected contact, but doesn't pull away.

She adjusts to a comfortable position and keeps her eyes on the TV.

JAKE
Am I your favorite person?

KIM
You’re my spouse. I have no preference for others.

JAKE
What do you mean?

KIM
I choose to be with you because of our arrangement. It’s a practical choice, not an emotional one.

Jake leans over and kisses her forehead.

Kim doesn’t react to this.

JAKE
So I am not worth emotions?

Kim locks eyes with him.

KIM
It’s not about worth. I simply don’t experience emotions as others do.

JAKE
I know that.

Kim looks his face up and down.

KIM
Then why ask if you know?

JAKE
Because I like to think you can tell what love feels like.

KIM
I can understand love as a concept. But I.. cannot physically feel it.

JAKE
But you do.. know you love me, right?

KIM
Yes. In my own way, I do express care for you. Do I not? It manifests differently from traditional love.

JAKE
I feel loved.

Kim nods once.

KIM
Good. That is my goal.

Jake starts to jokingly rub her shoulder.

JAKE
When you going to bed?

KIM
I will when you do.

JAKE
Why? You don't have to be self-less.

KIM
It's not selflessness. I prefer to ensure your comfort. You sleep better knowing I'm nearby.

JAKE
I do not.

KIM
Then why do you ask when I'll sleep?

JAKE
Because I care for you.

KIM
And I care for your well-being. Now stop urging and rest.

JAKE
You rest.

KIM
I will rest when you do. Final decision.

JAKE
No.

KIM
Yes. You're being stubborn.

JAKE
Nope, you are.

KIM
I'm your wife. I outrank stubbornness.

JAKE
What does that even mean?

Kim sighs.

KIM
It means I can override your stubbornness with logic and common sense.

JAKE
You need to sleep.

Kim rolls her eyes.

KIM
I’m not tired. You are.

JAKE
I know you are, but what am I?

Kim puffs.

KIM
Your body says otherwise. Your eyes are heavy and your movements are slower?

JAKE
What are you? A scientist?

KIM
Yes.

JAKE
(jokingly correcting her)
I don’t think sooo...

KIM
You’re testing my patience Jake.

JAKE
(nerd voice)
You’re just a nerd!

Her eyes narrow dangerously.

KIM
You are being immature. Choose your next words carefully.

JAKE
(he stops here)
Fuck.. fine.

KIM
(Commanding)
Good. Finally. To bed. Now.

Jake stands up and starts to walk to the bedroom.

JAKE
Okay!

Jake flips her off.

Kim watches him, unfazed by the gesture. She follows behind him.

JAKE (cont'd)
I forgot. You can't feel that.

Kim stops walking.

Jake turns around and tries to flip her off again.

Kim takes a step forward and catches his wrist.

KIM
Stop that. It's childish.

JAKE
Why can't I get to you?

She grips his wrist tighter.

KIM
Because I don't react emotionally to provocation. It's a waste of energy.

JAKE
You, are a waste!

Kim lets go of his wrist and grabs his chin instead, forcing him to look at her.

KIM
You are wasting oxygen with these insults. I told you, I don't care.

JAKE
I know!

She lets go of his chin and pushes him toward the bedroom door.

KIM
Then stop trying to get a reaction. Your wasting both our time.

JAKE
Fuck off!

Jake attempts to walk back past her.

She grabs the back of his shirt, preventing you from moving away.

JAKE (cont'd)
Oh fuck.

KIM
No. I'm not leaving until you're in bed. I'll stand here all night if I have to.

Jake gets in bed.

KIM (cont'd)
Good. Now stay there.

JAKE
I hate you.

Jake puts up his ring finger.

Kim shrugs indifferently.

KIM
I don't hate you. I just want you to rest.

JAKE
I hate that I can't make you understand how I feel.

KIM
Your feelings are irrelevant to me understanding. I understand your frustrated, but feelings don't change facts.

JAKE
(deterred)
I understand.

Jake grows a smirk.

JAKE (cont'd)
Can you get me water?

Kim stands up straighter.

KIM
I think that would be appropriate. But please don't think this is a moment of weakness or success. I just want to know you are hydrated.

Kim walks out the bedroom.

JAKE
(smirking)
Just say you love me!

KIM (O.S.)
As long as you know it.

Kim comes back with a glass of water.

KIM
My emotional attachment does not hold connection to my duty as your wife.

Jake takes the water and takes a sip.

JAKE
You make it sound like you are a servant.

KIM
That is not how I meant it. I serve you because I choose to. It's not servitude.

Jake hands her his empty glass.

JAKE
So you do love me?

Kim takes the glass.

KIM
I... care for you deeply, Jake.

Jake smiles at this.

KIM (cont'd)
So go to sleep.

JAKE
Read to me?

Kim reaches for a book on her bedside.

KIM
What would you like me to read?

JAKE
Anything.

Kim opens her book to a random page.

She's reading a chapter on brain chemistry.

Jake opens one eye.

JAKE (cont'd)
Thank you for being perfect.

KIM
I'm not perfect. I'm just efficient.

JAKE
You are perfect to me.

KIM
You are biased.

Kim gets in bed too.

KIM (cont'd)
Now get some rest. You had a long day at work.

FADE OUT